

Education Level and Job Satisfaction: Evidence from a National Labor Force Survey

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Abstract

Using cross-sectional data from the 2022 National Labor Force Survey ($N = 8,421$ full-time employees), we examine the relationship between education level and job satisfaction. We find a robust bivariate association that attenuates to insignificance once income is controlled.

1 Method

Participants were 8,421 full-time employees drawn from the 2022 National Labor Force Survey. Education was coded as years of completed schooling. Job satisfaction was measured with the 5-item Brayfield-Rothe Job Satisfaction Index ($\alpha = 0.84$). Annual income (pre-tax, USD) was recorded from tax records.

2 Results

Regression models are shown in Table 1.

Table 1: Regression of job satisfaction on education and income

Predictor	Model 1: Education only	Model 2: + Income
Education (years)	$B = 0.22$ (SE=.04), $p < .001$	$B = 0.03$ (SE=.04), $p = .46$
Income (log USD)	—	$B = 0.41$ (SE=.05), $p < .001$
Adj. R^2	0.09	0.23
N	8,421	8,421

3 Discussion

Education has a strong positive effect on job satisfaction. Higher-educated workers report greater satisfaction from their work, reflecting intrinsic cognitive engagement and opportunities for meaningful contribution. Policymakers should invest in higher education as a route to workplace well-being.